

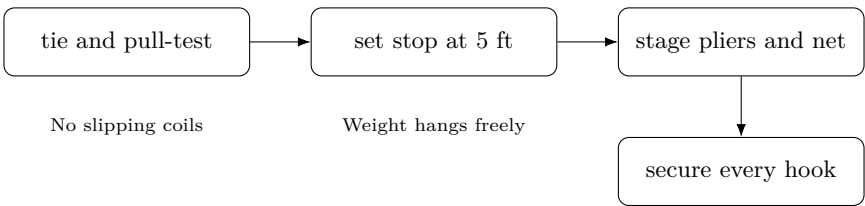
THE TRIP BEGINS WITH A LIVE CHECK

Confirm legal access, weather, exact-water 2026–27 rules, consumption advice, and posted boating ordinances. Leave a float plan. Return early for thunder, rising wind, poor visibility, equipment trouble, cold stress, unsafe traffic, or uncertainty about access or law. Wear the fitted PFD.

Pack by function

Function	Minimum kit	Observable check
Life safety	Fitted PFDs, whistle, phone in waterproof pouch, first aid, water, sun/weather layers	PFD closes snugly; phone is charged; float plan names ramp and return time.
Fish safely	Pliers, cutters, knotless rubber net, towel, ruler	Tools open one-handed; cutters sever the leader; ruler starts at a hard stop.
Fish simply	One slip bobber, one jig or split-shot rig, one spare of each	Every knot survives a firm pull; hooks are secured until launch.
Leave clean	AIS brush/bag, drain-plug reminder, trash container	No plant fragments remain on trailer, anchor, line, or livewell.

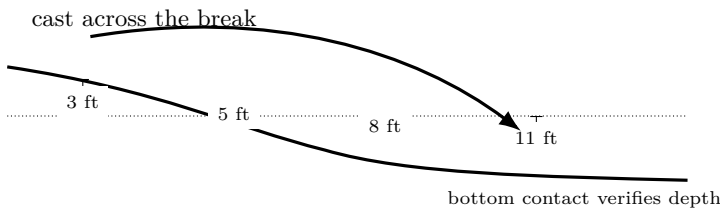
Rig and rehearse at home



Ask before leaving: Can I cast this rig without opening the tackle box? Can I reach cutters while seated? Can my partner state the return plan? If any answer is no, fix it on shore.

A measured two-hour search

Time	Job	Record before moving
0–15 min	Idle observation	Wind direction, visibility, surface temperature, plant height, traffic, and one safe return bearing.
15–60 min	One shallow edge	Starting stop depth; depth of each weed touch, bottom touch, bite, or fish. Adjust stop in 1-ft increments.
60–105 min	One break or saddle	Cast both across and along it. Record boat depth, lure depth, bottom character, and speed.
105–120 min	Close cleanly	Photograph notes; secure hooks; clean, drain, remove; message the float-plan contact.



The one-variable ladder

- 1. **Depth:** move the bobber stop 1 ft; make 5 attentive casts.
- 2. **Speed:** keep depth fixed; compare still, slow pull, then pause.
- 3. **Position:** shift one cast length along the same edge.
- 4. **Presentation:** change lure only after you can name the water column and cover already tested.

Intermediate question: Was “no bite” a complete test, or did the lure foul, miss depth, or spend most of the retrieve away from the feature?

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Corrective check
Bobber lies flat	Weight may be on bottom or missing. Shorten depth until it stands, then lower in measured steps.
Constant weed fouling	Confirm hook is clean every cast; move 1 ft shallower or parallel the outside edge.
Cannot repeat contact	Mark boat position and casting direction; reduce wind drift before changing lure.
Too many decisions	Return to one rig, one edge, and the next 1-ft depth step.

Trip complete when

You returned on time, left no plants or line, recorded at least one verified depth/cover observation, and can name the first test for the next visit. A catch is useful evidence, not the only measure of success.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; boating safety; PFD; AIS and bait law; 2026–27 regulations; NOAA/NWS inland boating.

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